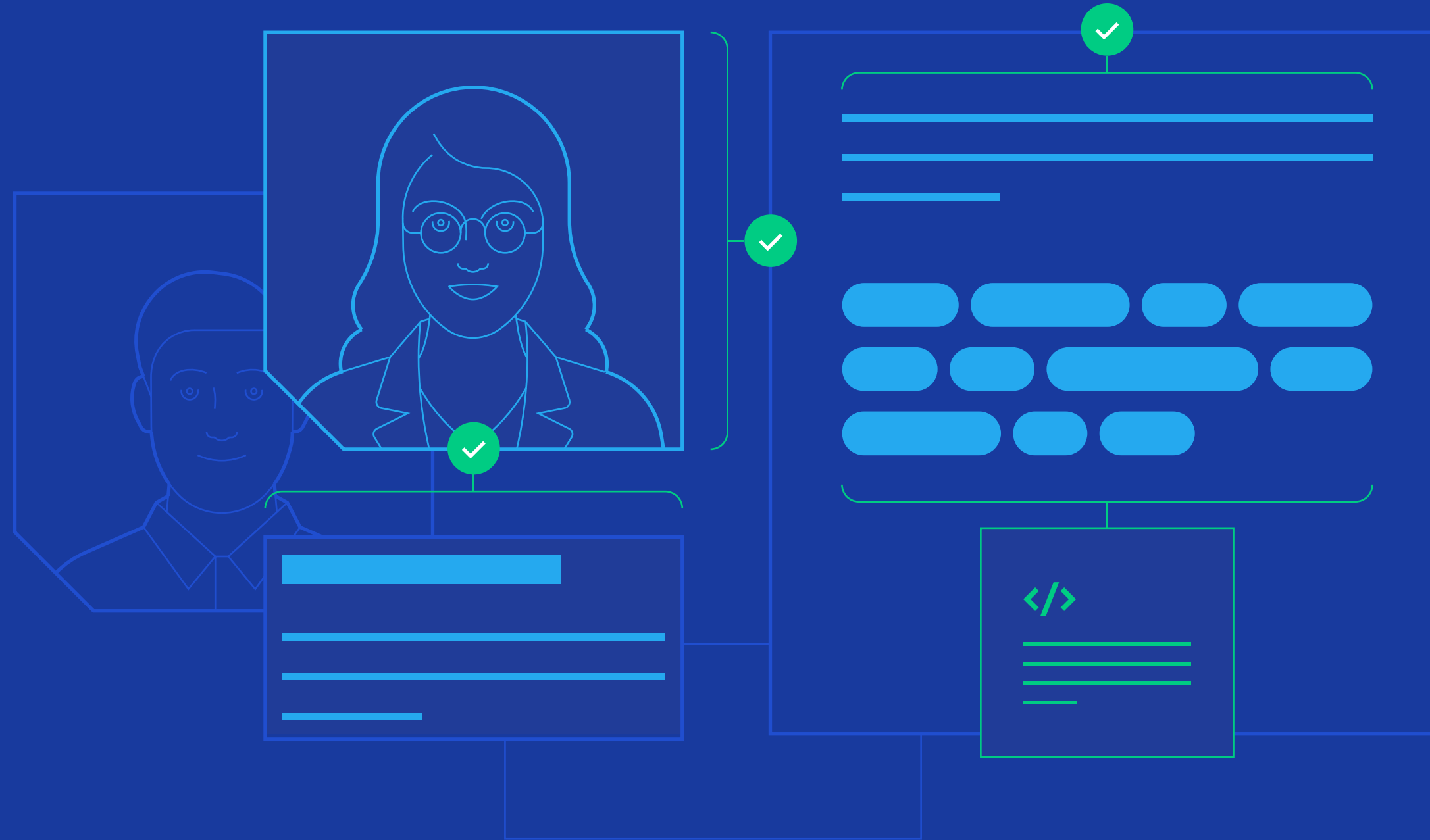




Getting Started

Developer Profile Guide

Confidential & Proprietary - For Internal Use Only

Introduction

Our tips, guidance, and recommendations for getting started at Toptal.

What is your public profile, and what is it used for?

Your Toptal profile is used as a marketing tool for both our internal matchers and our clients. Whenever Toptal selects you as a candidate for a project, your profile is sent to the client. While reading your profile, clients can decide whether you're the right fit for their project or not.

Why is it important to polish your profile to perfection?

Toptal responds to project requests with relevant and available talent within 24 hours, and over 90% of clients choose one of the initial candidates we propose. Detailed and compelling profiles make this possible.

The goal during your profile creation is to impress clients who receive your profile and make them want to interview you!





Structure of a Profile

1

Headshot

Upload a clear, professional-looking image of you against either a neutral background or a blurred out professional background (office/coworking space, etc.)

Edit Profile



Sergii Gulenok

Last updated on September 14, 2020

2

Basic Information

About

Craft a stellar "About" paragraph to hook clients into reading your whole profile.

"The most amazing..."

Share with us what makes you stand out from the crowd.

Basic Information

-  **Location:** Kiev
-  **Local Time:** 03:06 AM
-  **Languages:** English, Russian, Ukrainian
-  **Citizenship:** Ukraine

Contact Information

-  **Phone Number:** +16465830808
-  **Skype:** not set

About

Sergii has more than a decade of experience in IT, working as a software engineer (JavaScript and C# are particular strengths), project manager, and consultant. Thanks to a...

[Show more](#) 

Professional

Preferred environment: Jira, Slack, Vim Text Editor, VS Code, Linux, MacOS

“

The most amazing thing I've developed is the website and back office for a company that ranks among the top 5 online wholesale land marketplaces in US.





Structure of a Profile

3

Education

List your academic experience.

Education +

You added 1 school.

Taras Shevchenko National University of Kyiv
Master's degree - Kyiv, Ukraine

2002 – 2007

4

Work Experience

Provide detailed explanations of the work you've done in past positions to show the depth and impact of your professional experience.

Work Experience +

You added 5 jobs.

Lead Software Engineer | Project Manager

Okami Technologies OÜ · 2015 – Present

- Developed a wholesale land marketplace that ranks among the five largest in the US. Transformed it from a WordPress website into a platform with many external integrations, a subscription-based payment model, social network capabilities, and more.
- Created an internal performance and compensation review application for a unicorn startup. This custom implementation was preferable to any other tools available on the market and should become a profitable investment in less than a year.

Show More ▾

Senior Software Engineer | People Manager | Software Project Manager

Dentsply Implants NV · 2011 – 2016

- Built two medical software applications: a design 3D CAD tool for dental technicians and the tool to preview, process, and upload the 3D scans for the Atlantis™ Web Order system.
- Rebuilt the software core which allowed us to cut time for building new similar software applications by 20%. It reduced the codebase significantly, eliminated lots of boilerplate code, and resolved the root-cause of lingering issues.

Show More ▾





Structure of a Profile

5

Certifications

List your certifications.

Certifications +

You added 1 certification.

Functional Programming Principles in Scala
Coursera

6

Skills & Expertise

Call out all your specific skillsets and expertise.

Skills & Expertise

You added 71 skills.

★ JavaScript	7 years	★ C#	6 years
★ PHP	6 years	★ SQL	6 years
★ Python	4 years	★ MongoDB	3 years
★ React	3 years	★ GraphQL	2 years
Agile Software Develop...	10 years	Functional Programming	10 years
Linux	10 years	Object-oriented Progra...	10 years
Windows	9 years	API Architecture	8 years
C++	8 years	Code Architecture	8 years
Project Management	7 years	.NET	6 years
Git	6 years	GUI	6 years
Jira	6 years	LINQ	6 years
Mercurial	6 years	MySQL	6 years
REST	6 years	CSS	5 years





Structure of a Profile

7

Portfolio Projects

Demonstrate your highest-quality output to get clients excited about what you will deliver for them.

 Portfolio Projects 

You added 5 projects. You can drag and drop to rearrange the order.

Online Marketplace for Lands and Houses

<https://www.landcentury.com>

I had taken over this project about four years ago. I converted a simple WordPress-based website into the platform with a dedicated back office for listing management for the staff and several client-facing sites, the ...

Show More

Affiliate Marketing Network

<https://www.activeskill.com/>

I developed a network that connects brands with social media influencers. The website had reached the first 1,000 users in a bit more than a month using itself as a marketing tool and is on its way to returning initial in...

Show More

8

Time Zone & Working Hours

Your general work availability during the day. This information will help the system show you how much overlap you have with prospective jobs in the system.

 Time Zone & Working Hours 

Time Zone: (UTC+02:00) Europe - Zagreb

Preferred Working Hours: 12:00 PM - 09:00 PM

If needed, I can start working at 12:00 PM and finish at 09:00 PM

6

1

Headshots

A clean, professional headshot is a must in a Toptal profile. Assess your profile photos for quality based on the guidelines below, and make sure that all guidelines are met before submitting a new profile photo.

All Toptal profile photos should be:

High resolution

Photos need to be high resolution (at least 1000 pixels wide x 1000 pixels tall), in focus, and not grainy. Most 5MP and up camera phones will do the trick.

Well lit and in natural color

Whether inside or outside, make sure the lighting is even. An indoor flash is fine as long as the flash doesn't look obvious in your photo. When outside, avoid direct sunlight. Don't alter the original photo by adding overlays, filters, black and white conversions, circular frames, airbrushing, or vignettes.

Professional and pleasant

You should be dressed in business casual clothing and should be smiling or otherwise presenting a pleasant demeanor. Sweatshirts, graphic tees, and casual accessories such as headphones or sunglasses are discouraged.

Centered on your face

Have the camera at least 2.5 feet (80 cm) away from you so there's space around your head and shoulders. Only shoot from the shoulders up.

Simple

Light grey works best as a background color and avoid anything that's too light or too dark. If you go with a more complex background, inside or outside, the focus should be on you with the background blurred. You should be the only one in your photo so clear any distractions (like pets, friends, or even you looking like a big shot on stage) in the background or foreground.

Looking at the camera

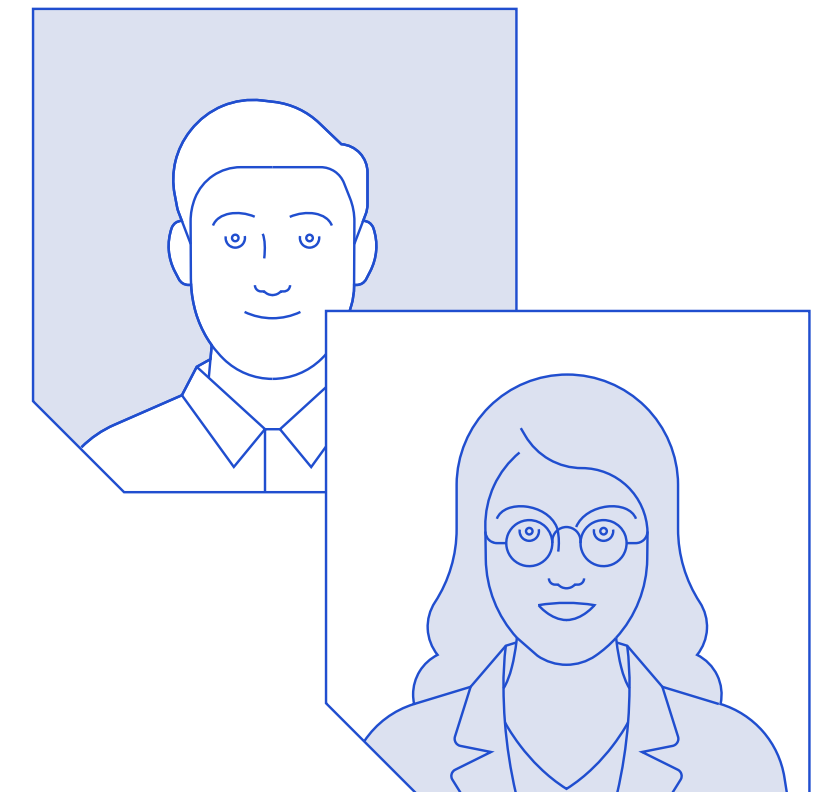
Eye contact is vital to a great headshot so look directly into the camera. Your eyes should be level with the lens.

How to pose

Smiles should be natural, not overly exaggerated or too subtle, and your facial expression should be professional and friendly. Good posture exudes confidence! Stand up straight and face the camera straight on or at a slight angle.

Your photo is one of the first things that a client sees.

Whether at Toptal or elsewhere on the web, the typical client or customer spends a mere fraction of a second glancing at a website for a product or service before making that first crucial judgment to explore further or click past, and even if only subconscious, a dedicated, professional headshot can be hugely impactful on a first impression.



2

Basic Information

The **About** paragraph should be about three sentences in length and in the third person. This is often used by matchers to provide a short summary of your experience when they introduce you to clients, so make sure it highlights your best and most relevant accomplishments. Keep the summary high-level and all-encompassing while providing specifics when possible.

Start off with trying to impress clients with a notable piece of work or professional achievement. Mention any well-known brand names, or give an indication of the scale of the work (e.g., number of active users, number of people on the team, notable achievements). Continue with describing your technical skills, experience, and specialties.

Try to find a sweet spot between mentioning specifics and describing your overall professional background.

Overall, it's most important to convey a clear idea of who you are, what you specialize in, how you do what you do, and why it helps clients. If you are able to work in how that ties into your passions and what you enjoy doing, all the better. However, be sure to keep the client focus first and foremost.

“ The most amazing...

Use the “most amazing” statement to describe a real-life scenario or project related to your career that made you proud of your skills. Try to provide information here that makes you stand out from other developers. Ensure that your statement is clear, specific, and includes detail. Avoid saying anything generic or not specific to you and your professional accomplishments.



3

Education

This section is primarily for degreed programs from a university (e.g., academic certificate, associate, bachelor's, master's, and higher, or an international equivalent) and may also be used for technical/vocational high school diplomas and International Baccalaureate (IB) certified secondary diplomas. Non-degreed programs and coursework associated in some way with one of these items (e.g., an exchange program embedded within a university degree or coursework toward an incomplete degree) are also acceptable.

If you have certificates, nano-degrees, online courses, or other exams, please list those in the "Certifications" section.



Master's degree in Finance
Bologna University - Bologna, Italy

2010–2016



Bachelor's degree in Computer Science
University of Los Angeles - Los Angeles, CA, USA

2010–2016



Bachelor's degree in Computer Science
Oxford University - England, United Kingdom

2010–2016



4

Work Experience

In this section, outline all of your relevant work experience as you would in a resume/CV. Include all of your years of experience related to software development, not just those related to the types of projects you are looking to pursue.

The bulleted lists under your positions are for specific accomplishments, not generic descriptions of ongoing duties or speculations on future achievements. This information will help our matchers and clients determine the relevance of your experiences and skillsets for the project at hand.

Add 3-10 bullet points (50-250 characters in length) for each position, starting with an active verb in the past tense and describing the experience in detail, including:

- Quantifying achievements whenever possible.
- Highlighting any unique skills.
- If possible or known, mentioning the specific result/outcome or effect of the work.

Examples of Bullet Points:

- “Developed an online travel agency engine which is used by more than 30,000 agencies worldwide.”
- “Implemented a continuously running, high-accuracy, low-energy-consuming location-tracking service.”
- “Used machine learning to predict information about candidates, allowing the company to simplify the registration process and improve registrations by 7%.”

It is important to be specific. Do not write vague or ambiguous statements, such as “Developed a website.”



5

Certifications

This section is primarily for nanodegrees, MOOCs, certificates, exam scores, and other verifiable professional qualifications (e.g., CPA, MSCP). It is not intended to display full university degrees and other established programs operated directly by an accredited university (e.g., Ph.D., MBA, Master of Science, Bachelor of Fine Arts, Associate, or academic certificate).



Advanced React Development
Computerhouse School

2018



Startup Acceleration Program
Computerhouse School

2018



Digital Marketing Course
Computerhouse School

2018



6

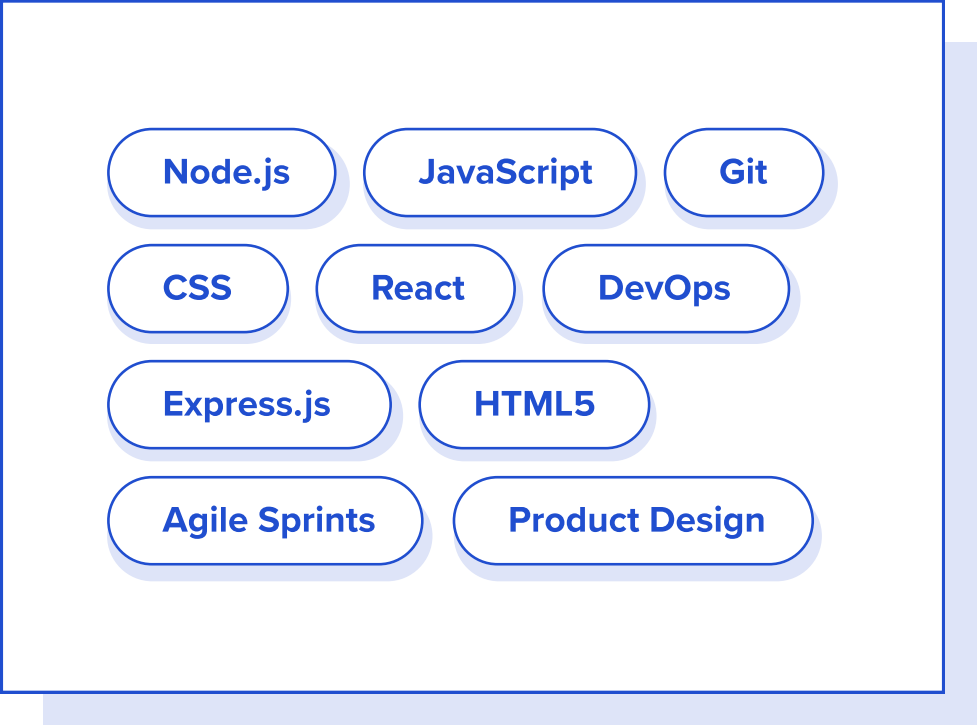
Skills & Expertise

The expertise section allows you to call out specific skillsets and expertise in seven categories. Be comprehensive in tagging all skills because we use these to determine if you're a good fit for a project. Also, you will qualify yourself as Competent, Strong, or Expert for each skill. Be balanced and don't oversell skills that might not be true expertise.

A series of skills appear under the "About" section of your public profile. These tags are generated by the platform based on the first 15 skills you've added to the "Skills & Expertise" section.

In the "Expertise" section, you are able to show up to 8 skills to highlight your skillset. When choosing your skills, be sure to include ONLY relevant tags associated with your primary and secondary skillsets.

Be sure to revisit your skills from time to time to keep everything up to date. Also, it's best to only list skills that you can attribute to a job or project, demonstrating your ability more concretely if asked about.



6.1

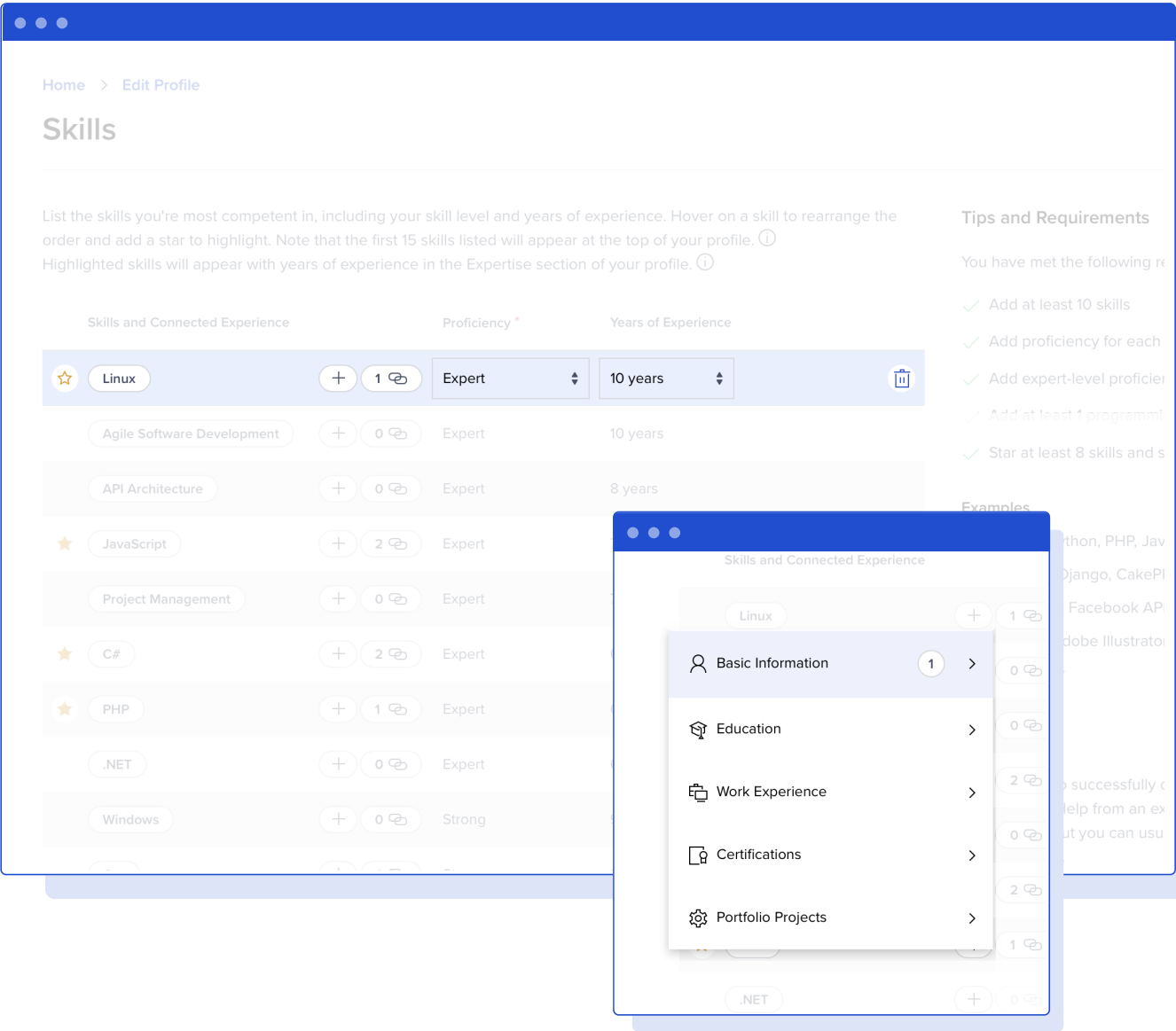
Skill Connections

New

In addition to selecting a level of expertise for your skills, you can connect any of your profile items (work experience, portfolio, certifications, and education) to skills to demonstrate where you honed your skills and how each contributed to your career.

When Toptal clients look for talent with a specific skill, they can immediately see that you have the respective skill and that it's supported by relevant experience.

Connecting skills to your previous experience will dramatically increase your likelihood of being introduced to clients and eventually getting hired.



7

Portfolio Projects

The purpose of the **Portfolio** section is to showcase individual projects or products that illustrate your skills and experience. While in the Employment section you'll list the things you did, the Portfolio Projects section is for things you made.

It's best to include high-quality examples of work you have done for clients, volunteering or as personal projects.

The portfolio items should be understandable on your profile without the need to reference an external website.

- Links should go directly to the project itself rather than an online portfolio.
- Your Toptal portfolio should highlight your creativity and thought process.



Online Marketplace for Lands and Houses

<https://www.landcentury.com>

I had taken over this project about four years ago. I converted a simple WordPress-based website into the platform with a dedicated back office for listing management for the staff and several client-facing sites, the biggest one of which is LandCentury.com. This redesign allowed us to extend the business model to provide subscription services to third-party sellers (increasing revenue by 25%) and internal ad network (which also increased the revenue by 10%), while at the same time reducing the operational cost.

[Show More](#)

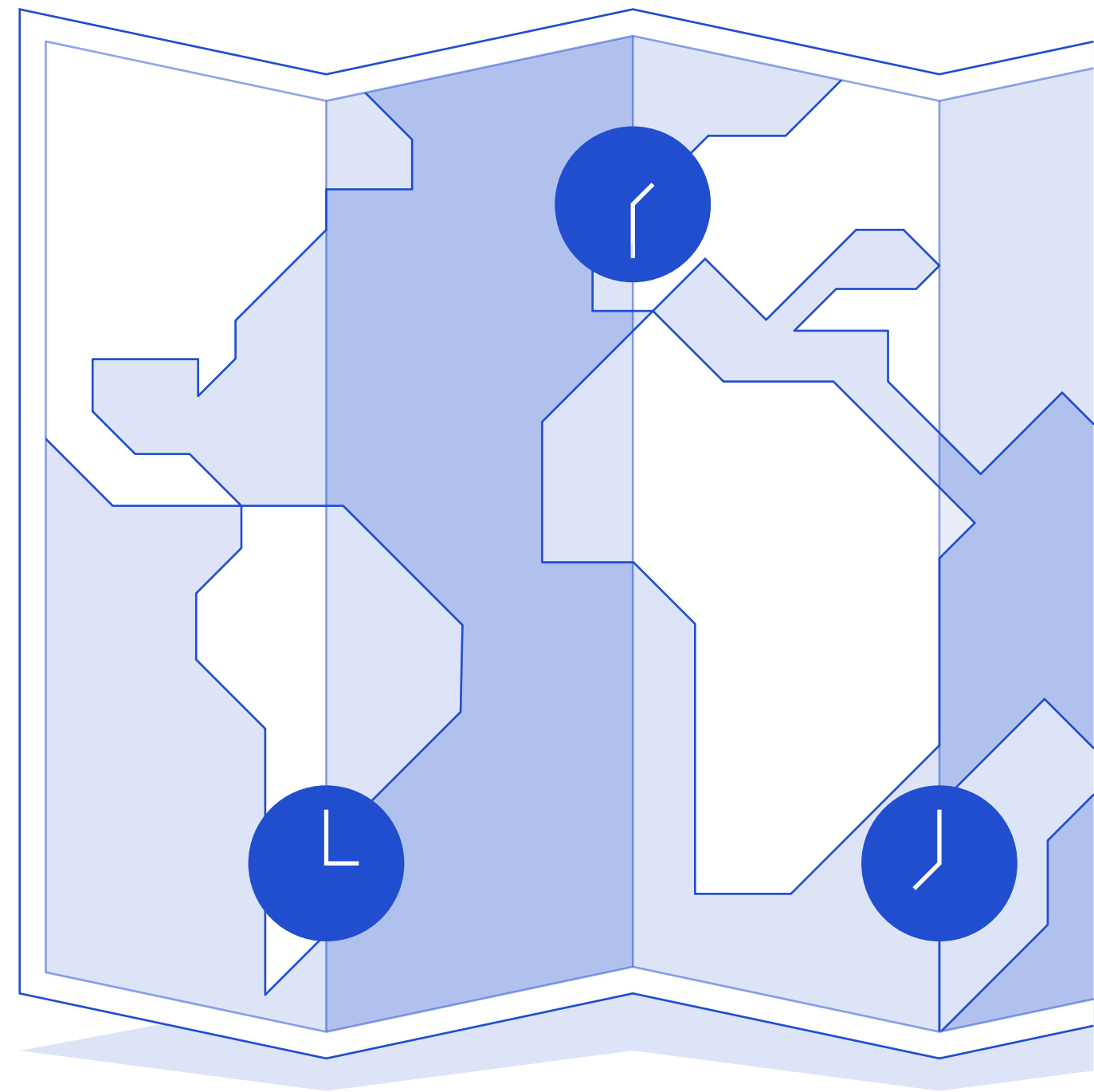


8

Time Zone & Working Hours

Working Hours refer to the period of your day that you are available to meet and interview with clients. It's akin to the hours you're generally available as if you were already working. Flexible Hours are the periods of time before or after your working hours that you would be potentially available to meet for the right project.

Flexible hours indicate that you are available for the occasional meeting in those time frames. You are not expected to work regularly during flexible hours.





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